

# Chapter 1

## The trouble with terrorism

An attempt upon a crowned head or a president is sensational enough in a way, but not so much as it used to be. It has entered into the general conception of the existence of all chiefs of state ... Now let us take an outrage upon—say—a church. Horrible enough at first sight no doubt, and yet not so effective as a person of ordinary mind might think. No matter how revolutionary and anarchist in inception, there would be fools enough to give such an outrage the character of a religious manifestation. And that would detract from the especial alarming significance we wish to give to the act ... You can't count upon their emotions either of pity or fear for very long. A bomb outrage to have any influence on public opinion must go beyond the intention of vengeance or terrorism. It must be purely destructive.

Joseph Conrad, *The Secret Agent* (1907)

Terrorism upsets people. It does so deliberately. That is its point, and that is why it now engrosses so much of our attention. Insecurity can take many forms, but nothing else plays quite so sharply on our sense of vulnerability. Terrorism is never easy to understand, and least of all in the aftermath of a terrorist attack. When society feels under threat, attempts at rational analysis are often openly resisted as giving aid and comfort to, or even sympathizing with, the enemy. Yet without such analysis, combating terrorism seems a baffling contest against an indefinite threat. Although terrorism can sometimes look rational, more often it seems to go straight off the chart of 'common sense'—being seen as not only unjustifiable, but atrocious, mad, or 'mindless'.

Something about terrorism makes its threat inflate, genie-like, way beyond its actual physical scale. Images of terrorism, in newspaper cartoons or on the covers of the avalanche of books on the subject published over the last

generation, typically set giant weapons against shrunken targets. Before 9/11 most writers on terrorism recognized that the physical threat posed by terrorism was dwarfed by other more everyday dangers. But even then, ordinary people, or their political representatives, showed little inclination to minimize the threat or put it in perspective. Often urged on by a mass media that magnified the public danger, politicians rushed to answer the implicit or explicit call for protective action. That action was, however, usually inconsistent and episodic; 9/11 called for more than this.

Terrorism shot to the top of the political agenda, and from then on it would be hard to contend that the damage it could cause was comparatively trivial, or even—a familiar argument—that its psychological effect was out of proportion to its physical effect. New York saw damage that looked like a wartime air raid (see [Figure 1](#)). Although the casualty list mercifully shrank from a potential 50,000 to less than 4,000, the vision of mass destruction, previously restricted to the kind of weapons possessed by only a handful of major powers, had appeared. The attack was deadlier, in terms of fatalities in a single day, than the bloodiest battles of the American Civil War. But, unlike in war, the destruction—however awesome—was isolated. No invading armies appeared. If this was war, it was far from the familiar, almost comforting, conventions of traditional warfare. As the dust settled, literally and figuratively, on Ground Zero, most of the questions that had always formed the puzzle of terrorism remained. If anything, the indefinite reach of President Bush's 'war against terror' underlined more sharply than ever the need for some definition—or compartmentalization—of this manipulable term.



**1. The attackers of New York's World Trade Center, on 11 September 2001, created an unparalleled shock effect, but signally failed to communicate their motivation and intention to their victims.**

## The problem of definition

Both political and academic efforts to get to grips with terrorism have repeatedly been hung up on the issue of definition, of distinguishing terrorism from

criminal violence or military action. Most writers have no trouble compiling a list of legal or other definitions running into dozens—and then adding their own to it. One well-known survey opens with a whole chapter on the issue; another managed to amass over a hundred definitions before concluding that the search for an ‘adequate’ definition was still on. Why the difficulty? In a word, it is labelling, because ‘terrorist’ is a description that has almost never been voluntarily adopted by any individual or group. It is applied to them by others, first and foremost by the governments of the states they attack. States have not been slow to brand violent opponents with this title, with its clear implications of inhumanity, criminality, and—perhaps most crucially—lack of real political support. Equally, states find it quite easy to produce definitions of terrorism. The USA, for instance, defines it as ‘the calculated use or threat of violence to inculcate fear, intended to coerce or intimidate governments or societies’; the UK as ‘the use or threat, for the purpose of advancing a political, religious, or ideological course of action, of serious violence against any person or property’.

Having done this, though, they tend to find it harder to specify the behaviour thus indicted; there is no specifically ‘terrorist’ action that is not already a crime under the ordinary law. Instead, they label certain organizations as ‘terrorist’ and make membership of them an offence, and they draw up schedules of proscribed offences such as possession of explosives or taking hostages. Britain has come up with an offence called ‘preparation of an act of terrorism’, which seems to echo the notorious conspiracy laws of earlier times. Ultimately, terrorism appears to be defined by intention rather than behaviour.

The problem here is that state definitions simply assume that the use of violence by ‘subnational groups’ (as the US Department of State’s definition has it) is automatically illegal. In the state’s view, it alone has the right to use force. But outsiders may wonder whether all use of violence by non-state actors is equally unjustifiable, even if it is formally illegal. The very first revolutionary terrorists in the modern sense, as we shall see in [Chapter 4](#), believed themselves justified in opposing with violence a repressive regime in which no freedom of political expression or organization was permitted. And, crucially, many foreign critics of Tsarist Russia—governments included—agreed with them. Such differences of perspective gave rise to the notorious adage that ‘one person’s terrorist is another’s freedom fighter’. This relativism is central to the impossibility of finding an uncontentious definition of terrorism.

Some writers have suggested that instead of pursuing the will-o'-the-wisp of precise definition (one specialist has called terrorism 'a box with a false bottom') it would make more sense to construct a typology of the kinds of actions that are generally seen as 'terrorist'. It is certainly the case that many kinds of action repeatedly used by terrorist groups—assassination, kidnapping, hijacking—are seldom if ever used in conventional military conflicts; they do seem to signal a special type of violence. But any such list soon peters out: too many terrorist actions duplicate either military or criminal acts. In any case, it is, in the end, not so much the actions themselves that are characteristic of terrorism, as their intended political function. 'Terror is simply a tactic, a method of random violence', as the political scientist Sunil Khilnani says, 'as likely to be used by a deranged individual as by a state. But *terrorism* is a distinctive form of modern political agency, intended to threaten the ability of a state to ensure the security of its members'—and thus its claim to legitimacy. To get closer to a definition of terrorism we need to unpick its political logic. For the core of nearly all definitions of terrorism—the use of violence for political ends—is too similar to the definition of war to be of much use.

## Terrorism and war

Clearly war and terror are intimately related. It is hard to imagine a war that did not generate extreme fear among many people, and sometimes this is more than a by-product of violence—it is a primary objective. Historically, the sacking of captured cities was definitely intended to intimidate the inhabitants of other fortified positions. Most recently, the fighters of Islamic State in Syria and Iraq have used the most untrammelled violence to terrorize their enemies. In between, the development of strategic air bombing, though it had a strictly military rationale—to avoid the costly stalemate of trench warfare as experienced in the First World War—was based on a psychological theory: the belief that it would undermine the morale of the enemy population. In the words of one of its founding fathers, Lord Trenchard, in a bombing duel the enemy 'would squeal before we did'. In the event, this belief proved to be, if not false, certainly exaggerated, so the scale of destruction required to implement it after 1940 became vastly greater than had previously been imagined (or possible).

By the time of the gigantic raids on Hamburg and Dresden, the description of the RAF's operations as terror bombing was not merely the rhetoric of Goebbels's propaganda ministry: this was undeniably a deliberate attack on noncombatants.

Even so, the dreams of the apostles of air power—the Wellsian nightmares of the civilians—did not become reality. The Second World War was not won by bombing. It has proved difficult to determine precisely the role it played—whether ‘decisive’ or not—but it was ultimately auxiliary to the kind of traditional military action so despised by airmen. And neither has any subsequent war been won by bombing alone. In war, fear may be a potent weapon, but it is not an omnipotent one.

One way of distinguishing war from terrorism might be to say that war is what states do, terrorism is done by those too weak to oppose states openly. But this misses the point that the weak may adopt a strategy of resistance that does not require terror. Guerrilla warfare, however ‘unconventional’ by regular military criteria, operates by normal military logic. Guerrilla fighters engage the state’s armed forces, on however small a physical scale, and however protracted or episodic a timescale, and thus fulfil Clausewitz’s requirement that war be ‘the collision of two living forces’, not ‘the action of a living force upon a lifeless mass’. In other words, the defining process of war is combat.

The essence of terrorism, by contrast, is not just avoidance but negation of combat. Terrorist targets are attacked in a way that prohibits self-defence. And what makes terrorism so alarming is the readiness to attack not just selected but also random targets; in the indiscriminate bombing of a street market, a store, or a bar, we see a deliberate flouting of the international law of war, and a refusal to accept as binding the prevailing moral distinctions—between belligerents and neutrals, combatants and noncombatants, legitimate and illegitimate targets. So the vital part of the US definition is ‘noncombatant targets’ against whom violence is ‘perpetrated’ (here the terminology conveys the official anathema).

These may not be ‘the innocent’ necessarily: the attempt to transfer the notion of ‘innocent civilians’ from the international law of war to the study of terrorism has foundered on the realization that innocence is another relative, unstable quality. It was, for instance, impossible for people fighting against Germany in the Second World War to accept that most German civilians (with the exception of the regime’s political opponents who were in concentration camps) bore no responsibility at all for the existence and conduct of the Nazi regime. They were assumed to be legitimate targets for indiscriminate blockade (as had been the less democratically empowered citizens of the much less criminal Second Reich during the First World War). Did they deserve even the protection from direct



attack that international law guaranteed them, much less protection against indirect ('collateral') injury? (Not if you took the Churchillian line that 'they have sown the wind, they shall reap the whirlwind'.)

But of course most Germans felt substantially innocent, heightening their sense of unfairness when they were deliberately targeted by the British bombers. And in politics, as distinct from courts of law, subjective belief and feeling are supreme. The feeling of innocence, together with vulnerability, form crucial elements in what may be called the 'process of terror'—the process by which violence generates political effects. This provides a key to what I shall call 'pure' terrorism. Targets may not be in an objective sense innocent, but they must be in practical terms defenceless ('soft'). The essence of terrorism is the use of violence by the armed against the unarmed. But how does this work? We can distinguish three elements in the process of terror.

*The terror process 1: seizing attention—shock, horror, fear, or revulsion*

This is certainly the most straightforward stage. People's need for order and security impels societies to establish conventions and boundaries to regulate violent coercion: when these are transgressed, shock is generated. Moreover the special quality of terrorist acts—attacking the defenceless—dramatically magnifies the anxiety about security which is never far below the surface of society. Some writers have argued that fear as such is not a crucial factor—the mere excitement of violence may generate sufficient impact—and this may be true. But it is the sense of disturbance, of abnormality if not enormity, that seizes attention.

*The terror process 2: getting the message—what do terrorists want?*

This is a much more complex and less predictable part of the process. By no means do all terrorist groups rush to claim responsibility for their actions, or if they do so, deliver a comprehensible rationale or demand. When (presumed) 'terrorist' acts are left 'unsigned'—like Pan Am 103—it is up to the onlookers to fill in the blanks. The results can be varied. Controversy over responsibility for the destruction of Pan Am 103 over Lockerbie, Scotland, in December 1988 has persisted ever since; in 2005, a senior Scottish police officer alleged that the evidence on which the Libyan Abdelbaset al-Megrahi was convicted in 2001

was planted. (The Scottish government's release of al-Megrahi on medical grounds in 2009 provoked an international incident.) George W. Bush assured his citizens that the September 2001 attacks were 'intended to frighten our nation into chaos and retreat'. But retreat from what, or where? American commentators, both official and unofficial, showed a marked reluctance to accept the fairly well-established view that Osama bin Laden's primary *casus belli* against the USA was the defilement of Saudi Arabia by the presence of US troops. Instead they preferred more abstract explanations of the attacks rooted in envy or hostility towards American prosperity and democracy. A special counsellor to the President, Karen Hughes, explained 'they hate us because we elect our leaders'. Even though Osama bin Laden had declared war on the USA in 1996, his specific charges (such as defilement of Muslim territory by US troops) were scarcely considered. Indeed, his declaration was largely ignored for a decade, partly because it was, as Mary Habeck suggests, couched in language 'largely incomprehensible to non-Muslims'. The Spanish government tried to pin responsibility for the Madrid train bombing in March 2004 on ETA; (unusually) it suffered electoral defeat for the perceived deception.

There is clearly a difference between the comprehensibility of terrorist acts designed to achieve limited objectives, for example the release of an organization's members, or some specific political concession, and those whose objectives are revolutionary—whether in the social, spiritual, or ethnic sphere (liberation, independence). These varied messages may be communicated by the violent act itself ('propaganda by deed'), but there is a likelihood of misunderstanding unless it is reinforced by a clear statement.

*The terror process 3: fight or flight?—the response*

Partly because the assessment of motives can be quirky, responses can be erratic or contradictory. If the demands are comprehensible and fulfillable, fear may drive people to comply. Ordinary people may be able to fulfil minimal demands—to keep quiet and refuse to help the police, for instance—but bigger political demands can't usually be delivered by them. The people most likely to be intimidated by terrorist acts are the people who, in most political structures, are outside the decision-making sphere. (Those inside it, police or military chiefs and government ministers, are well-protected and professionally debarred from panic.) Can public fear really change policy? Terrorists themselves often seem vague about this crucial link in the process.



Terrorism theorists have distinguished between ‘targets’ and ‘resonant mass’, the latter being presumed to be the force that could generate the sort of political pressure that might oblige governments to comply. (So fear, or fascination, must be focused tightly enough to ensure a connection; if its effect is too diffuse the mass will not resonate at the right frequency.) The degree and focal intensity of pressure required will vary according to the ‘extremity’ of the demand. Where there might be supposed to be a simple cost–benefit calculation—as for instance with the Irish Republican Army’s (IRA) cherished notion that under consistent attack the British public would eventually decide that it was not worth maintaining British forces in Ireland—the process might in theory be straightforward. In practice, however, public reactions can be perverse. The reaction to the 1974 Birmingham pub bombings by the IRA, for instance, was not a demand for British withdrawal but an insistence on refusal to concede to violence. So there is an alternative third-stage scenario in which, instead of securing compliance, terrorism provokes a violent state reaction—which will either destroy the terrorist organization or, by ‘unmasking’ the inherent violence of the system, destroy the state’s own legitimacy.

## Strategies of terror

Thinking about the terror process suggests that there are significant functional differences between what some writers have called ‘types’ of terror. In the 1960s, the pioneering work of T. P. Thornton proposed two basic varieties: ‘enforcement’ and ‘agitational’ terror. The function of enforcement terror is likely to be limited, aimed at preserving the security of the rebel organization by deterring the public from giving information to the security forces. To succeed in this, the organization needs a sufficiently extensive surveillance system to persuade people that assisting the authorities will be detected: most terrorist groups are simply too small for this. (On the other hand, the security of small clandestine groups is much easier to maintain by secrecy alone: only when an organization tries to interface with the public do its risks multiply significantly.) Thus enforcement terror has usually been a by-product of a guerrilla campaign—as it was in Ireland (1920–1), Vietnam (1945–50), Algeria (1950s), Palestine (1936–9)—where it was fairly easy for people to grasp terrorist requirements and at least partly comply with them. (See [Box 1](#).)

## Box 1

The great thing about anarchist vengeance is that it proclaims loud and clear for everyone to hear—that this man or that man must die for this and this reason; and that at the first opportunity which presents itself for the realization of such a threat, the rascal in question is really and truly dispatched to the other world.

And this is indeed what happened with Alexander Romanov, with Messenzoff, with Sudeikin, with Bloch and Hlubeck, with Rumpff, and with others. Once such an action has been carried out, the important thing is that the world learns of it *from the revolutionaries*, so that everyone knows what the position is.

Johannes Most, *Freiheit*, 25 July 1885

Agitational terror is likely to grasp at much larger goals—‘revolution’ of some kind, or ‘national liberation’. Some of these goals are more feasible than others. In the colonial context, a cost–benefit analysis may plausibly favour a terrorist strategy, since imperial rulers may be prepared to cut their losses and quit. In internal conflict, the stakes are usually much higher—the survival of the political elite or even its hegemonic structure (‘private property’, ‘capitalist institutions’). For this elite, no benefit is likely to outweigh the costs of concession—so the struggle will probably escalate. Whereas ‘compliance’ may be secured by low levels of carefully targeted violence, agitational violence will intensify, and targeting may become indiscriminate in order to maximize shock. Here the outcome depends on whether the terrorists are generally perceived as public enemies or outlaws, *hostes humani generis*, with whom no meaningful interaction is acceptable.

Thornton’s basic typology remains persuasive, though later writers have added further refinements. In an exceptionally lucid case study of revolutionary terrorism focused on the Algerian FLN (*Front de Libération nationale*; National Liberation Front), Martha Crenshaw suggested that the support-building function of terrorism encompassed two quite distinct aims: first, securing obedience or compliance (what Thornton called ‘enforcement’); and, second, bidding for

sympathy and ideological or moral endorsement. This ‘inspiring’ quality is often neglected, especially by conservative writers who wish to deny any legitimacy to violent action in pursuit of radical or revolutionary goals.

Endorsement may be the aim not only of revolutionary but also of counter-revolutionary, right-wing, or reactionary terror, dedicated to the prevention of change or the recovery of a former political order. This ‘white terror’ is often triggered by revolutionary change or the threat of it, and is characteristically pro-state—like, for example, the array of Ulster loyalist paramilitary groups—but if the state is seen as already under alien domination, such groups can be impelled to attack the state they claim to be defending. The most spectacular and disturbing outbreak of this syndrome in recent years is the libertarian or white-supremacist ‘militias’ in the USA, who hold that the federal government and its agencies, such as the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), are under the control of a ‘Zionist world government’ (or indeed shapeshifting extraterrestrial lizards, for the surprisingly numerous adherents of David Icke) dedicated to the destruction of American liberty. Timothy McVeigh’s bomb attack in Oklahoma City in 1995 ([Figure 2](#)) seems to have been conceived as a rallying-call to bring Americans to their senses, to make them see how things really are. Anders Behring Breivik’s slaughter of seventy-seven people in Norway in 2011 was intended to alert Europe to its ‘cultural suicide’ in the face of Islam. This stands, as we shall see, in a long tradition of propaganda by deed.



**2. The Federal Building in Oklahoma City was a target that symbolized the power of government to its opponents in the Christian militias. It was bombed in April 1995, on the anniversary of the burning of the Branch Davidian compound in Waco, Texas, during an assault by federal agents; but none of the 168 who died were members of the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco and Firearms which the building housed.**

Terrorist action may be auxiliary—one element of a larger military or guerrilla strategy; it may be confined to limited goals (revenge, publicity, political statement, release of prisoners, ethnic autonomy); or it may be self-sufficient—pursuing its goals through the systematic use of terror alone. It is this independent terror strategy, rather than terrorist action per se, that should properly be labelled ‘terrorism’. It has a unique logic, which we can trace across the last century. It was first distinctly outlined in Johannes Most’s *Philosophy of the Bomb*, an anarchist tract of the 1880s, and rests on a number of connected propositions:

- 1 Outrageous violence will seize the public imagination



- 2 Its audience can thus be awakened to political issues
- 3 Violence is inherently empowering, and 'a cleansing force' (as the later anti-colonial writer Frantz Fanon put it)
- 4 Systematic violence can threaten the state and impel it into delegitimizing reactions
- 5 Violence can destabilize the social order and threaten social breakdown (the 'spiral of terror' and counterterror)
- 6 Ultimately the people will reject the government and turn to the 'terrorists'.

Thus terrorism properly so called is not just the use of violence for political ends; not just outrageous violence; not just violence by the armed against the unarmed; it is conceived as a free-standing, sufficient, and decisive political strategy.

## Organization and arms

Users of this strategy have taken many shapes and forms. Some terrorist groups have been quite large: the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria may be seen as, in effect, a terrorist army. More usually they have been very small. The internal dynamics of large and small groups are different. (Roughly speaking, five seems to be the minimum number for a functional group; while groups bigger than eight or nine have to change in nature—they need more substantial funding, for one thing.) The new networks of the social-media age are different again, allowing individuals to sign up to the organization's core ideology, then plan and act alone—the so-called 'lone wolf' operation. (The 2017 Manchester concert bomber funded his attack with a student loan.) Such individual attacks were common—perhaps unsurprisingly—with 19th-century anarchists, but became rarer, confined to odd characters like the Unabomber and Anders Breivik, with their own special agendas.

The 'lone wolf' label has come to be applied to what appeared to be a new phenomenon, the 'homegrown' or 'cleanskin' terrorist—someone outside the established surveillance focus on organizations. Originally embraced by white supremacists in the USA in the 1990s, it has been widespread since al-Qaida's call in 2005 for jihadis to strike by themselves, killing unbelievers 'wherever you find them'. Since then, it has repeated this Quranic injunction frequently. The 'lone wolf' idea has been invoked for a raft of attacks, including the Boston marathon bombing in 2013, the 2016 Nice and Berlin truck rampages, and the Westminster attack in March 2017. This is probably misleading, obscuring the

extent to which almost all attackers pick up their agenda (and their technology) from existing structures, such as what Jason Burke calls ‘the fertile and desperately depressing world of online jihadism’.

The scale of operations, and the kind of weapons used, have also varied along with organizational shifts. Bombs were iconic for anarchists; if guns were used for assassinations they were small enough to be concealable. Recent jihadist attacks have used formidable service rifles like the AK-47, whether in the hands of groups—as in the Mumbai attack—or individuals. Key factors here are access to such weapons (harder in some countries than others) and readiness to kill indiscriminately. Bombs remain key weapons for most terrorists, but still present technical challenges of construction and detonation. Bombs carried on ‘suicide vests’ or belts have now become such icons for a generation of jihadis that some attackers have recently sported fakes. Other weapons present no problems of availability—such as the rental car used in the Westminster attack mentioned earlier, the knives used to kill a Catholic priest in a Rouen church in 2016, or the two combined with even deadlier effects at London Bridge in 2017. Knives of any kind can be effective—the 9/11 attackers took control of three aircraft with pocket utility knives—but long hunting knives may well heighten the visceral sense of fear in an event like the London Bridge attack, in which some victims had their throats cut. Whether public alarm over the increase in ‘knife crime’ more generally magnified this effect is not clear. In any case, though, there has to be a belief that such apparently random killings, which the attackers often do not survive, form part of a larger pattern carried on by others.

## Terror and politics

Thinking about the terror process leads to the conclusion that the essential distinction between war and terrorism lies in their operational logic: war is ultimately coercive; terrorism is persuasive. War is in essence physical; terrorism is mental. (This is not to say that war is exclusively a matter of physical force; one of Napoleon Bonaparte’s maxims was that ‘in war the moral is to the physical as three is to one’. But if we were to hazard an equivalent ratio for terrorism, it might be more like 3,000, if not three million.) The point is that the physical power of terrorism can in principle be minuscule. Although fatalities from terrorist action have dramatically increased in weak states such as Iraq, Afghanistan, and Nigeria, in functioning states they remain numerically insignificant.



Terrorism operates, therefore, through subjective psychological pressure. Its biggest facilitator is collective alarmism, a regrettably banal phenomenon that has been registered in the White House as well as middle-class suburbs and peasant villages across the world. The essential precursor of the Great Terror of the French Revolution was the ‘Great Fear’ which spread across France in the summer of 1789. This irrational panic was not only symptomatic of pre-modern society—as many 20th-century ‘spy scares’ demonstrated. Rumour remains one of the most subversive social processes.

Pure terrorism resolves the discrepancy between actual destructive power and desired political effect by an almost mystical belief in the transformative potential of violence. Some writers have identified this as the ‘sacralization of violence’; but without invoking mysticism we can see that terrorist logic clearly rests on a symbolic conception of sociopolitical power relations. Here the complexities, delays, and mistakes of the regular political process can be short-circuited, or we might say ‘hotwired’, by violence—which will lay bare the deeper reality of collective allegiance.

This simplified view of politics may also explain a problem set up by many writers on terrorism—how can terrorists (who far from being ‘criminals, crusaders, and crazies’ emerge in most good empirical studies as ‘disturbingly normal’ people) go out and kill innocent people in cold blood? A typical example is the assertion that terrorists need to be ‘without the human emotions of pity or remorse’. This suggestion of moral deformity results from a false antinomy between ‘cold blood’ and the ‘heat of battle’—the latter being what supposedly makes it possible for ordinary people to kill in war. Both these concepts are very treacherous. In the modern world, certainly, the ethical mechanism by which ordinary people have been able to set aside pity and remorse in order to kill other ordinary people has been symbolic generalization—the smothering of the victims’ individual human qualities by their collective identity (whether religion, class, race, or ethnicity). Far from being at all monstrous (in the sense of unusual), this kind of stereotyping powered most, if not all, of the wars, genocide, and violent revolutionary struggles of the 20th century, and remains the common currency of nationalist discourse and the motor of ‘ethnic cleansing’. If terrorists are ‘fanatics of simplicity’, so are all too many good citizens. Most terrorists, like so many of those who have taken part in mass murder, are disturbingly normal.

## Women and terrorism

Another striking contrast between terrorism and war has been the remarkable prominence of women in terrorist operations. From Vera Zasulich, who carried out the first *Narodnik* armed attack when she shot the governor of St Petersburg in 1878, to Wafa Idris ([Figure 3](#)), the first female Arab ‘suicide bomber’ in Israel in January 2002, women have been front-line actors and, consequently, pioneer recasters of gender roles. Indeed, something like a quarter of the Russian terrorists of the 19th century were women; a proportion possibly exceeded among the German and American terrorists of the 1970s. A full third (33 per cent) of the Communists Organized for the Liberation of the Proletariat (COLP) in Italy were women, and 31 per cent of that nation’s Brigade Rosse (BR; Red Brigades). Is this because terrorist actions, small-scale and not calling for traditional military ‘combat’, are inherently less physically demanding? (Though women also formed a third of Colombia’s Revolutionary Armed Forces—FARC—which conducted a fifty-year rural guerrilla campaign from the mid-1960s.) Or because terrorist groups (with some notable exceptions) have tended to be progressive? Or merely because they are too small to generate the characteristic militarism or *machismo* of regular armies? It’s hard to say: the few serious studies so far have focused on women’s motivation rather than the dynamics of these organizations.



**3. Wafa Idris, the first female Palestinian ‘suicide bomber’, or self-martyr, wearing the insignia of al-Fatah before her mission to a Jerusalem shopping centre.**

The prominence of women has been noticed from time to time (though we should note that even where they are prominent, they remain a minority), and seems to invite some explanation. One eminent authority on terrorism, Walter Laqueur, has recently offered the somewhat Olympian assertion that ‘women terrorists are more fanatical and have a greater capacity for suffering. Their motivation is predominantly emotional and can not be shaken through intellectual argument.’ Such speculations, which seem to hover close to traditional stereotypes, invite a number of questions—what, for instance, do we understand by the label ‘fanatical’? The role of many women in ‘martyrdom

operations' (over one-third of Chechen suicide bombers between 2000 and 2010 were women, known as the 'Black Widows') may well be explained less extravagantly—revenge for the torture and killing of their brothers and husbands.

Geula Cohen, a fighter with the Zionist 'Stern Gang' (Lehi) in Palestine in the 1940s, offered this account of her first reading of Lehi's bulletin *HeChazit*: 'It was the first time in my life that the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet had arranged themselves on a page especially for me. I felt that I was writing rather than reading the words.' This was instant identification. Still she saw differences between herself and her male comrades:

Whenever I accompanied any of the men as they set out for an action, I always noticed the same expectant gleam in their eyes and the same tense, yearning look on their faces, an anticipation of some longed-for object of sacrifice, and I knew that here was a spark of that primeval fire in which truth is born ... the kind of tension from which the artist surely springs.

For her, biology ruled that women were never born to be artists, or combatants: men would perform better on the battlefield not only because they were stronger, 'but also because their spirit thirsts more than yours does to vanquish the death which you shall one day conquer within your own body.'

In the last generation, the proportion of women in terrorist groups has continued to rise, and women have carried out some of the most spectacular attacks—like the Shabaab suicide bomber who assassinated her uncle the Somali Interior Minister in 2011. They have figured noticeably in the emergence of the 'self-radicalizing' lone terrorist. When, for instance, Roshonara Chaudhry decided to assassinate the MP Stephen Timms, who supported the invasion of Iraq, she seems to have had no direct contact with any Islamist group. In her final year at King's College London—on track for a first-class degree—she had read the sermons of Anwar al-Awlaki online; she carried the most basic of weapons—a couple of knives. Arrested after wounding the MP, she explained that because 'he had no mercy for the Iraqi people', he deserved none.

Women may often play a key role in supplying the 'connectivity' in new social networks. But their role in leadership seems not to have grown correspondingly, either in nationalist or in religious groups. Women still accept subordination for reasons that may appear obvious in the case of religious fundamentalists, while

in the secular world there has never been any close fit between nationalism and feminism. Some of the most strident anti-feminist views, indeed, seem to come from women nationalists.